

PHISHING AWARENESS TRAINING



**BEFORE YOU CLICK
STOP · CHECK · VERIFY**

CodeAlpha Cyber Security Internship - Task 2

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MODULE OBJECTIVES

What this awareness module covers

01 Recognize phishing messages

Identify suspicious emails, SMS messages, fake websites, and unexpected requests.

02 Understand attacker tactics

See how urgency, trust, fear, curiosity, and authority are used to manipulate people.

03 Respond safely

Use a simple workflow: stop, verify using trusted channels, report, and delete.

Outcome: safer daily decisions when handling links, attachments, credentials, and login alerts.

WHAT IS PHISHING?

A social engineering attack, not just a technical problem

Phishing is a cyberattack where an attacker pretends to be a trusted person or organization to trick the victim into sharing sensitive information or performing an unsafe action.

- Login credentials
- Banking and payment details
- Personal data
- Company accounts
- Multi-factor authentication codes



**ONE BAD CLICK
CAN OPEN THE DOOR**

TRUSTED LOOK → URGENT REQUEST → CLICK / OPEN → DATA LOSS

Phishing works because it targets human trust, routine, and time pressure.

COMMON TYPES OF PHISHING

Attackers change the channel, but the goal remains the same

Email phishing

Mass or targeted messages with fake links and attachments.

Smishing

Phishing through SMS or messaging applications.

Clone phishing

A copied legitimate email with a malicious replacement link.

Spear phishing

Personalized messages aimed at a specific person or team.

Vishing

Phone calls pretending to be support, banks, or management.

Fake websites

Look-alike login pages used to steal credentials.

Key idea: always verify the request, not only the sender name or logo.

ANATOMY OF A PHISHING EMAIL

A simulated example for training

From: Security Team <security-alert@company-support.com>
Subject: Urgent: Account verification required

Hello user,

We detected unusual login activity. Your account will be locked in 30 minutes unless you confirm your password immediately.

Click here to verify:
<http://company-login.verify-now.example.com>

Regards,
Support Team

Verify Now

RED FLAGS

Sender mismatch

The domain is not the real company domain.

Urgency pressure

The message tries to make the user act fast.

Credential request

A legitimate team should not ask for passwords.

Suspicious link

The link uses an unfamiliar domain and HTTP.

FAKE WEBSITES AND URL CHECKS

Look beyond the logo and page design

Example URL

```
http ://com pany-log in .verify-now .exam ple .com /log in
```

Protocol

HTTPS is not a guarantee, but HTTP is a warning sign for login pages.

Spelling

Look for extra words, swapped letters, or look-alike characters.

Domain

Read from right to left: example.com is the real domain here.

Source

Open the site from a bookmark or by typing the known address.

Rule: do not log in from links in unexpected messages.

SOCIAL ENGINEERING TACTICS

Phishing is designed to influence emotion and decision-making

Authority

Pretending to be IT, HR, a manager, a bank, or a trusted vendor.

Urgency

Creating a deadline so the victim acts before thinking.

Fear

Threatening account closure, penalties, or data loss.

Curiosity

Using fake documents, invoices, offers, or delivery alerts.

Trust

Imitating logos, signatures, language, and previous conversations.

Reward

Promising prizes, refunds, bonuses, or exclusive access.

If a message makes you rush, pause first.

SAFE RESPONSE WORKFLOW

A simple process to follow before clicking

STOP



CHECK



VERIFY



REPORT

Do not click, download, reply, or enter credentials.

Inspect sender, domain, grammar, link destination, and attachment type.

Contact the organization using a known phone number or official website.

Report to IT/security or mark as phishing/spam, then delete.

When in doubt, verify through a separate trusted channel.

BEST PRACTICES TO STAY SAFE

Small habits reduce the chance of a successful attack

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|---|
| ✓ Use MFA | Enable multi-factor authentication on important accounts. |
| ✓ Use strong passwords | Use a password manager and unique passwords for each service. |
| ✓ Keep systems updated | Updates close known weaknesses used in attacks. |
| ✓ Do not reuse credentials | One stolen password should not unlock multiple accounts. |
| ✓ Avoid unknown attachments | Do not open unexpected files, especially archives or executables. |
| ✓ Report suspicious messages | Reporting helps others and supports early detection. |

REAL-WORLD PHISHING SCENARIOS

Examples of messages users should verify

Suspicious login alert

"We noticed unusual activity. Click here to secure your account."

Delivery notification

"Your package is on hold. Pay a small fee to release it."

Fake invoice

"Your unpaid invoice is attached. Open immediately to avoid penalty."

Password reset request

"Your mailbox will be disabled unless you confirm your password."

These examples are simulated for training and should be treated as suspicious until verified.

INTERACTIVE QUIZ

Choose the safest answer

1. An unexpected email asks you to verify your password through a link. What should you do?
2. Which is more suspicious: <http://bank-login.example.com> or <https://bank.com>?
3. A message creates urgent pressure to act in 10 minutes. What is the safest first step?
4. A file named Invoice.pdf.exe arrives unexpectedly. Should you open it?
5. If you clicked a suspicious link and entered a password, what should you do next?

Discuss the answers before moving to the next slide.

QUIZ ANSWERS AND FINAL TAKEAWAY

Phishing defense is a repeatable habit

1. Do not click. Visit the official site or contact support through a trusted channel.
2. The first URL is suspicious because example.com is the real domain, not bank.com.
3. Stop and verify. Urgency is a common manipulation tactic.
4. No. The double extension suggests an executable disguised as a document.
5. Change the password, enable/check MFA, report the incident, and review account activity.

Final takeaway

Before clicking a link, opening an attachment, or entering credentials, pause and verify the request through a trusted source.

References: FTC Consumer Advice, CISA security awareness guidance, CodeAlpha Task 2 instructions.